

Lesson 7

Acceptance (Part 1) - Putting Down the Mental Fight

Acceptance is one of the most misunderstood concepts in healing. Most people think that acceptance means I love what's happening, and I agree that it should have happened and that it must be permanent, so I'm gonna give up. So it really does make sense why people resist it so much. I resisted it too.

When I first heard about the concept of acceptance, I thought it was the worst advice idea I had ever received. I was suffering so much and someone was just telling me to just accept it. To me that felt like being told to lie down, let it win, let it get worse until you die, to give up on hoping that things would ever get better for me.

And so if that's where you are at right now, and if that's, if that's the resistance that you feel, I get that because I was there too. I was there for probably a little too long. But what I eventually realized was that I was not resisting acceptance. What I was resisting was like a version of acceptance that I made up in my head, which isn't exactly what acceptance is.

So let me start with what Acceptance is not. Acceptance is not liking how you feel. It's not believing your symptoms are permanent. It's not giving up on healing or believing that you'll ever get better, and it's not deciding that things are never gonna change for you. For way too long, I thought acceptance meant accepting that things were really bad and they were only gonna get worse and worse, and I needed to be okay with that.

That obviously felt impossible, like why would I accept that? But that's not what acceptance is. Acceptance and resignation are not the same thing. Acceptance is stopping the mental fight with what's already here. It is stopping the argument with reality. It's the difference between saying, this shouldn't be happening and this is what is happening.

I want you to think about acceptance as your relationship. To your situation, this is the broader picture of where you are at right now. Not this moment, not this sensation, but the overall reality that this is the phase of life that you are in. The mental fight. Sounds like this should not be happening. I should be further along.

This should be getting better. Someone should be able to help me. This should have had a clear solution by now, and why is this happening to me? All of those are thoughts about your situation, and every single one of them is resistance. Acceptance is putting down that fight. It's saying, this is where

I am right now, today.

This is my reality. That doesn't mean it's my reality forever. It doesn't mean I'm giving up. It doesn't mean I love this or that I'm okay staying here. It just means that I'm done arguing with the fact that this is where I am today. One of the biggest shifts for me was moving from how can I escape this?

How can I fix this to, how can I get better at being with this? That is what acceptance is. It's a willingness to have the experience that's already here. You don't have to want it. You just have to stop fighting. Its existence because fighting, it is not working. Here's the way I want you to think about it.

Imagine that you're carrying a heavy backpack. You didn't choose this backpack. It just showed up. It's yours to carry. It is strapped onto you. Acceptance is saying, this is my backpack. This is what I'm carrying today. I don't have to like it. I don't have to pretend it's not heavy, but I accept that today.

This is what's on my back. This is what we're working with. That's very different from stopping every two minutes to resent the backpack and wish you had packed lighter and argue with the fact that you even have to carry this freaking backpack at all. That is the mental fight. That's the resistance.

There's a difference here between pain and suffering. Pain is the sensation in this situation, the uncomfortable experience. What's showing up for you, what you're in the middle of. It sucks, but it's reality. Suffering is what we add on top of it. That's the resistance, the fighting, the analyzing, the fearing, the obsessing.

All of it is driven by this belief that this should not be happening. Pain is unavoidable sometimes we are human. Life has pain, but suffering is created by how we respond to that pain. And when you are constantly resisting what you're feeling, you're not just experiencing the original discomfort, you're now layering suffering on top of it.

In my experience, the suffering often feels worse than the pain itself. There were moments where I was like, I cannot fight both my body and my brain. They've teamed up against me. I found acceptance removes that layer of suffering. The pain might still be there, the experience might still be there, but you underestimate how much better you can feel when you drop that war that's going on inside of you.

If acceptance feels scary to you again, that makes sense. Your mind is going to equate acceptance with danger because when you're living in that fear, you believe, if I accept this, it's going to stay. Like if I stop fighting, I'm giving up any chance of getting better. It really does feel like giving up.

You feel like if you don't spend your time resisting and fixing and doing something about this, then you're not doing anything. The truth is that that mental fight is contributing to keeping that alarm on. Your mind believes that fighting is what is keeping you safe. It does not realize that the fight itself is what is part of keeping you stuck.

Here's something I really want you to hear. Everyone wants to know how to accept. They want to know that they're doing it right. They're trying to accept harder except better, except the right way, but that's not really how this works. Acceptance isn't like an action. It's not something you do. The way I see it is, it's what's left.

When you stop resisting. So the great news is you don't have to figure out how to accept. You have to stop fighting. Acceptance is the byproduct of putting down the resistance. It's not about accepting better, it's about resisting less. So when you're struggling with acceptance, flip it around and instead of asking, how do I do acceptance?

Ask yourself, where am I actively resisting right now? Because resistance is the opposite of accepting. If you can spot where you're fighting, you can start to put that fight down, and when you put it down, you're already in acceptance. You didn't have to do anything special. You just stopped the thing that was keeping you out of it.

I spent a very long time mentally fighting my symptoms. All of these shoulds, it should have had a clear solution. Someone should have been able to help me. It should be getting better by now. All of that was resistance. All of it was keeping me stuck. When you stop fighting, a few things will start to shift for you.

The internal pressure that you have that you've lived with for so long will begin to lower the mental noise, the looping thoughts, the panicked racing thinking begins to decrease. Things will not escalate the same way they used to. You will feel like you have a little more room to breathe. Nothing externally is going to change super quickly at first, but internally, the inner war you've had with your mind and your nervous system will begin to quiet.

You are not constantly fighting yourself, and what you will find is that you have more energy for everything else because you're not exhausted from fighting all day. That is what acceptance gives you. It is not a cure. It's less war with yourself. And here's the bigger picture. When you're not doing all of that mental resisting, you're sending a signal of safety to your brain because you've removed the signal of danger.

Acceptance is something that rewires the brain and the danger circuits in the brain. It is not just a nice concept. It is how you start to change the pattern. Acceptance is not one decision. It is not something that happens all at once. It is not something you can do perfectly, and it's not a switch you just flip on.

You don't just say, I accept this, and then you're done. Your mind is going to go into resistance and fighting automatically again and again and again. That's what it has been trained to do. Your job is to notice when that is happening and to put down the fight over and over and over again, and in time it becomes less frequent, it becomes less intense, and you soften into acceptance over time.

It's something that you return to. It is not something that you arrive at and then you're done. In the next lesson, I'm gonna show you what acceptance actually looks like when the resistance shows up, what it sounds like internally, how to spot when you're resisting without realizing it, and what helped

me to practice this in the middle of my actual life.